

ANI

## POWER BANK OF THE BJP

- **The party is positioning itself as a champion of the OBCs and is promising to appoint a member from the cohort as Telangana's next chief minister**
- **It has nominated 37 candidates from the backward classes, which may even surpass the number fielded by other parties**
- **PM Modi is addressing five rallies. On October 1, he laid foundation stones and dedicated multiple developmental projects worth Rs 13,545 crore**
- **The chink in its armour? Some analysts say the BJP now favours the BRS's return to power—seen as a strategic move to prevent the Congress from seizing power**

edge the possibility of BJP exerting influence in the event of a hung assembly, most analysts and opinion polls give the party very slim chance of wresting power on its own. The most optimistic assessment predicts 11 seats and a vote share of nearly 15 per cent. Several factors have diminished BJP's chances—Kishan Reddy replacing Bandi Sanjay as state party chief not the least of them. The party's inability to clear the air on the allegations of a BJP-BRS nexus, internal conflicts between old-timers and newcomers and a lack of clarity in funding have also played a role in dissuading senior members from contesting and expressing reluctance to do so.

Since it cannot come to power on its own, the BJP is now perceived to be concentrating its efforts on not letting the Congress seize power either. Despite their public posturing, people do not believe their denials of a tacit agreement with the BRS. "Despite the BJP's ticket distribution accommodating caste and community cohorts, there is a perception about an unwritten understanding with the BRS to keep the Congress out," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches Political Science at the NALSAR University, Hyderabad. "It seems the BJP is interested in just keeping its traditional voters in its groove and making minor incremental gains. They are settled to be friendly with the BRS though they know they cannot get along with the regional party in the long run."

The mid-term game plan is to maximise electoral gains leading up to the 2024 general election, with the goal of surpassing the four MPs elected from Telangana in 2019. The BJP delayed finalising contestants in order to welcome disgruntled heavyweights from both the BRS and the Congress. The party has awarded tickets to at least 11 former MLAs and three ex-MPs from other parties—a move designed to consolidate its voter base in preparation for the upcoming Lok Sabha election.

The BJP seems confident of improving its prospects, even if simmering discontent led to Komati Rajagopal Reddy, chairman of the screening committee for candidate selection, and the manifesto committee chairman G. Vivek resigning and returning to the Congress. There is also growing concern among the seniors that favouring new entrants might hurt the party's chances.

Another factor that may not go in the BJP's favour is the alliance with Kalyan to get the support of the 'settler' votes of Andhra Pradesh natives in Telangana, especially in the Greater Hyderabad and Khammam regions. This has met with disapproval within the party as several leaders believe it will benefit the BRS—considering the fact that the JSP has never contested the state election. Some argue that expecting miracles from Kalyan, who had a disastrous electoral debut in Andhra, losing both the assembly constituencies he contested from, is too much. The alliance could well prove counterproductive for the BJP; at best, it may be a prelude to how it will work in contiguous Andhra next year. The BJP, though, is leaving no stone unturned—Kalyan is but one part of its overall strategy. ■